10 Copilot in OneNote

OneNote is an ideal app where Copilot can show its potential. It can help organize random thoughts that can then be pasted into slides or documents. If you're an avid *note* taker, keep reading!

Intended Uses

Microsoft publishes what they know will work well, both in its in-app prompt menu and in the Copilot Prompt Gallery. Here is a general summary about what's possible in OneNote (at the time of writing):

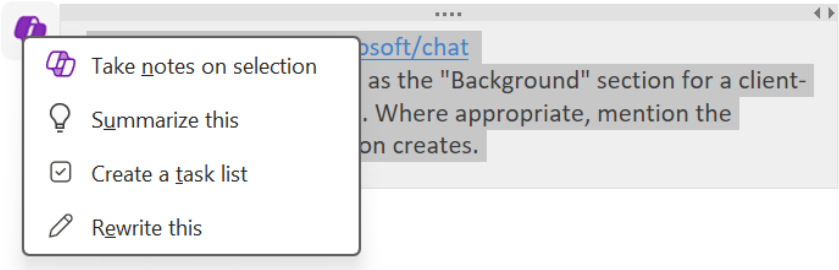
Feature	Description
Organize	Synthesize your chicken scratch.
Summarize	Paraphrase an entire section, a selection of text, or a specific topic.
Rewrite	Improve clarity and verbiage.
Search	Find all your notes on a specific topic.
Ideate and Create	Make agendas, outlines, and to-do lists, analyze ideas, ask questions, and get suggestions.

Activating Copilot within OneNote

As usual, activate Copilot from the upper right-hand side of the ribbon under your picture / name. Once you click to open the Copilot pane, you're ready to organize your thoughts, ask questions, or create to-do lists.

You can also interact with Copilot within OneNote in the body of the notes. With a click, you're able to summarize content, draft actionable task lists, or update any portion (or the entirety) of your notes.

The on-screen experience is activated by highlighting a section of notes and then choosing from the options shown.



This on-screen experience is only available in OneNote for Microsoft 365 (the desktop app), not in the web browser experience.

Using Copilot in OneNote to its Fullest

The following tables summarize the main capabilities and constraints of using Copilot in OneNote.

Organize

Capabilities	Constraints	Prompting Tips
Organize Content Combine bullets into paragraphs Break paragraphs down into steps	Only the active page is analyzed. The response will not populate inside the OneNote. It'll be added to the right-hand chat box. Copying and pasting the response into a Word or PowerPoint will then allow you to continue to hone it.	"Organize the information into clear sections with headings, such as 'Current Situation', 'Gaps', 'Proposed Solutions', and 'Assumptions'" "Organize the information into clear sections with headings, such as 'Technology', 'Costs, 'Challenges', and 'People.'" "Break down the <topic> plan into steps."

Summarize

Capabilities	Caveats	Prompting Tips
Summarize a long list of notes or body of text	Try this on an entire page, or if there are specific sections you want to summarize, highlight them and select “Summarize this” or type “Summarize the highlighted section.”	"Summarize these notes for key takeaways for IT professionals working in the xyz industry." “What are some of the constraints and risks?” "Summarize the main arguments in the notes."

Rewrite and Improve

Capabilities	Caveats	Prompting Tips
Rewrite bullet points as a paragraph Improve sentence clarity or writing quality	The rewrites will occur in the right-hand window, not on-screen. Watch your cursor (see “Troubleshooting” below).	Highlight the entire section or sentences you want to rewrite, then: Click “Rewrite this” or type prompts like: "Rewrite these bullet points into a cohesive paragraph." "Improve the clarity of this sentence." “Expand upon this (highlighted) section and make it sound more professional, as if it were written by a <xyz> industry executive.”

Search

Capabilities	Caveats	Prompting Tips
Find the notes on a specific topic	Responses may return more than just content in OneNote. That's because the right-hand pane is just Microsoft 365 Chat working inside of OneNote.	"Find all notes about <Topic>" "Find the notes about <Topic> that are only within OneNote."

Ideate & Create

Capabilities	Constraints	Prompting Tips
Create an outline Ideate and get suggestions Brainstorm a meeting agenda Create a task list	The capabilities here are similar to those available in M365 Copilot Chat.	"Create an outline for a blog post on <xyz topic>" "What are the problems that need to be solved?" then "How would you suggest solving them?" "Brainstorm an agenda for the upcoming <department or industry> meeting agenda" Click "Create a task list" or type "Draft a to-do list from these notes" or "Draft a to-do list from these notes for a <job role> trying to <state your goal> in the <relevant industry> business

Pro Tips in OneNote

1. To write a custom prompt, use the right-hand chat box. At the time of writing, the inline Copilot wizard within the notes themselves won't allow you to write anything custom.
2. You can compare/confirm that your notes have been embedded into more formal documents (i.e. reports, contracts, memos). For instance, in the right-hand window, ask "Did this information appear in the latest <description> contract?" Copilot will find related contracts in SharePoint or OneDrive, then scan whether it contained your notes.
3. At the time of this writing, Copilot's full functionality is limited to the OneNote for Windows application. There is **no official word on when or if Copilot will be available for the web version** of OneNote. You *can* bring up the standard Copilot chat box from within OneNote on the web, just not the inline Copilot wizard within the notes. Within the right-hand chat window, you can "Summarize" a section or a notebook, or "Rewrite," but the changes appear in the chat window only, not inline on the notes page.
4. Don't bother googling something from a browser when you need information. **Type your search in the right-hand chat box and Copilot will provide a response**, which you can then copy and paste into OneNote. This is true for the chat box within all Microsoft 365 apps.
5. You might find it useful to save your favorite / frequently used Copilot prompts in OneNote for faster access!